

# The Boston Globe

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## COVID is back, but threat isn't the same

Hospitalizations, deaths are low; patients getting better more quickly

By Jason Laughlin  
GLOBE STAFF

Earlier this year, Dr. Jeremy Faust noticed what he considered a remarkable COVID landmark that came and went with little fanfare.

From early May through early August, COVID was virtually nonexistent in Massachusetts' waste water. During that roughly three-month period, the virus claimed fewer than 10 lives, a record low

over the past six years.

"We literally had, essentially, nearly undetectable levels," said Faust, an emergency physician at Brigham and Women's Hospital who also researches public health. "This is, honestly, shockingly low and great."

After that lull, COVID levels are ticking back up in Massachusetts, as they do every fall and winter. It's a small increase, though, and emer-

gency room visits, hospitalizations, and deaths remain at record lows. People with COVID are also clearing infections faster, Faust said.

"Honestly, when I see a COVID case I am no more alarmed than I am when I see an influenza case," he said.

Seven years ago, virologists and epidemiologists predicted that as human immune systems became accustomed to the new virus, COVID would eventually fade into the mix of endemic respiratory illnesses. That moment is here, many experts say.

It's possible, some experts said, that severe illness and mortality from COVID will become even less frequent over time.

While physicians differ on whether COVID is truly no more hazardous than flu, federal data show the illnesses now trigger a comparable number of deaths. The Centers for Disease Control and Prevention estimated that overall flu deaths from October 2024 to April 2025, the most recent confirmed data available, were about 45,000. COVID deaths were estimated to

COVID, Page A10

## Accounts diverge as Farwell case starts

Both sides rely on texts to describe woman's last days

By Sean Cotter, Laura Crimaldi,  
and Camilo Fonseca  
GLOBE STAFF

The murder trial of former Stoughton police detective Matthew Farwell opened Friday in US District Court in Boston with vivid, dueling accounts of the last day in the life of the young pregnant woman he stands accused of killing.

As prosecutors told the jury, the day of her death, Feb. 1, 2021, was the culmination of eight years of abuse: Farwell had been having sex with Sandra Birchmore since she was a 15-year-old member of a police youth program and he a 27-year-old instructor, but had studiously kept the affair secret, Assistant US Attorney Torey B. Cummings said.

Farwell used sex to dominate Birchmore, Cummings said, and had sent her at least 20 messages in which he talked about choking her during the act.

But Birchmore, Cummings said, asserted herself, using his fear that others would learn of their relationship to gain leverage over Farwell. Eventually at age 23 she pushed him to impregnate her. And when she did become pregnant, Farwell discovered that at least one of her friends knew they were having sex and had revealed their relationship to Stoughton police; that, Cummings added, made Farwell feel like he was losing control of the

FARWELL, Page A7

## New leaders for longtime churches

At Jubilee Christian, bishop's consecration marks a full circle moment



By Niki Griswold  
GLOBE STAFF

It was nearly 11 on a Friday night, and the sanctuary of Jubilee Christian Church in Mattapan was still packed with hundreds of parishioners. Nearly four hours into a service filled with rousing songs and sermons, the crowd hushed as it focused on the clergy — and the three generations of Thompson men at the center.

The church's lead pastor, Matthew K. Thompson Sr., bowed his head as his 26-year-old son anointed him with oil. Thompson's father stood above him, praying.

Then, in a moment that captivated the crowd, Thompson stood before his congregation bearing a gifted sword and shield, and, for the first time, a new title: bishop. The



PHOTOS BY MARK STOCKWELL FOR THE BOSTON GLOBE

Top: Senior Pastor Matthew K. Thompson Sr. worshiped at Jubilee Christian Church last week before he was consecrated as a bishop. Above: Members of the congregation celebrated during Thompson's consecration ceremony.

audience erupted into cheers.

In the nondenominational church, Thompson's consecration ceremony last week marked his elevation to a senior clergy position — a pastor who leads and counsels other pastors. He is part of a new generation of clergy ascending to leadership roles at Black churches around Boston — a trend that points to the institutions' efforts to evolve with the times.

The consecration also represented the next chapter in his family's role in the community, as Thompson was anointed with the same title as his father, Bishop Gideon Thompson, who founded Jubilee Christian Church more than 40 years ago.

Today, Jubilee has grown into one of the largest nondenomination-

JUBILEE, Page A10

## More details emerge in Reading death

A dispute over cats, a hint of violence, and 19 guns

By John R. Ellement, Travis Andersen,  
and Lea Skene  
GLOBE STAFF

and Bryan Hecht  
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

READING — There was an argument over all the rescue cats his mother took in. She wanted him to move out; his father told him to get a job. There was also an ominous message a friend received from Ryan Hanafin Wednesday night, hinting at violence.

Those are some of the harrowing new details revealed in a police report on Friday about the shooting death of Andria Hanafin in the kitchen of her family's suburban home in Reading. Police also disclosed they found 19 guns in the bedroom of her eldest son, who has been charged with her murder and firearm offenses.

Ryan Hanafin was arrested Thursday in Vermont, where he fled in the hours after the shooting. During a brief court appearance Friday afternoon, Ryan Hanafin agreed to be returned to Mas-

READING, Page A7

## Sununu runs again but in a changed N.H.

Shifting political landscape puts certainties to the test

By James Pindell  
GLOBE STAFF

BEDFORD, N.H. — If Republican John E. Sununu wins New Hampshire's open Senate seat next month, he will return to Washington after 18 years away, the longest gap in modern US history for any returning senator.

But the electoral map in New Hampshire looks nothing like it did when Sununu first won in 2002 or when he lost in 2008. Yes, New Hampshire remains a swing state, but the Donald Trump era has realigned the political landscape so thoroughly that the shifts within any one community — from red to blue and sometimes back again — can be dizzying.

And, few places have changed more than Bedford, Sununu's former hometown and once a pillar of his support.

When he moved to Bedford a decade ago, Drew Cline recalls that the showy cars dropping kids off

SUNUNU, Page A6



SOPHIE PARK/GETTY IMAGES

John E. Sununu, the Republican running to replace retiring Senator Jeanne Shaheen in New Hampshire, met voters last week in Loudon, N.H.



Finders, peepers

**Saturday:** Sunny, high clouds. High: 63-68. Low: 48-53.

**Sunday:** Sun early, then rain. High: 63-68. Low: 52-57. Sunrise: 6:51 Sunset: 6:10 Comics and Weather, **D4-5.**

Obituaries, **C9.**

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**Navi Pillay, a South African-born jurist and former UN human rights chief, won the Nobel Peace Prize** for efforts that the award committee said promoted international law as it comes under attack. **A4.**

**Mike Ditka has died at 86.**

He personified the toughness and grit of Chicago in an NFL Hall of Fame career as a player and coach of the Bears. **C9.**



**Nurses at Boston Medical Center voted to ratify a new contract,** but negotiations between nurses and Brigham and Women's Hospital did not produce a deal. **D1.**